| SILKYARA RESCUERS | UTTARAKHAND |

FOR 17 DAYS IN NOVEMBER, ALL EYES IN INDIA REMAINED FIXED on TV screens. It was a nail-biting rescue operation that was grabbing all their attention. The government had deployed its full might—all the ultramodern machinery and technologies it could lay its hands on—to rescue 41 workers trapped inside a 4.5-km under-construction tunnel that had collapsed at Silkyara in Uttarakhand. In the end, however, it was a group of 12 "rat-hole miners" who—with the help of their manual tools—burrowed through tonnes of debris and completed the last stretch of a rescue tunnel, something even an American drilling machine had struggled to do for days. They gained instant celebrity status. And rat-hole-mining—the antiquated, now-illegal practice where narrow holes are dug manually to extract coal—caught everyone's imagination.

One small detail, however, got buried under all the celebrations: in reality these men were not rat-hole miners at all. "I don't know who first called us that. Let alone knowing how to do it, we had never even heard of rat-hole mining before this," says Vaqeel Hasan Rangrez, the leader of the group, laughing. "Our company issued a clarification but no one took note of that."

Rangrez's Delhi-based company, Rockwell Enterprises, is engaged in what is called manual pipe-jacking, also known as "trenchless" work. The 12 were called in—two groups of six each from Uttar Pradesh and Delhi—when the auger machine was finding it hard to pierce the debris. The misnomer perhaps stuck because their skill is to crawl into tight spaces to repair water or sewer pipes.

ROUGH-CUT GEMS

› The rescue team, foisted with the name 'rat-hole miners', were actually skilled manual pipe-jackers in trenchless work

› The team's manual digging successfully completed the rescue passage, and got them to the 41 labourers trapped inside the collapsed tunnel

Braving the risk of getting buried under the debris, the rescuers worked in shifts round the clock and finished digging in 27 hours

Facing unexpected hardness repeatedly while drilling for an 800-mm diameter rescue tunnel, the auger got stuck multiple times and its rotor broke off. So the government decided to give manual digging a shot. "We got a call on the 22nd (day 11 of the rescue operation). Until then we had never even heard of the place. Like everyone else, we had only seen the news on TV and YouTube," says Rangrez, co-owner of Rockwell.

The team was given the option to stay at a nearby hotel but they refused. "We chose to stay in the camp at the site; we wanted to contribute as much as possible," says Munna Qureshi, 29, also a co-owner of Rockwell. Soon after taking stock of the tunnel, Rangrez told the officials that the auger machine would get stuck and that his team should be deployed as soon as possible. "The machine got stuck soon after. That's when we started work," he says.

Braving the risk of getting buried under the debris, teams of four worked in shifts round the clock and finished the job in 27 hours: two crawled in to extract the muck and handed it over to the other two outside, as efficient as an assembly line. Munna became the face of the rescue mission as he was seen on TV to be the first one to cross over to the other side of the tunnel and greet the entrapped workers on the evening of November 28. "The workers started cheering the moment I cleared the last bit of debris with my tool and emerged on the other side. They hugged me and I told them the whole world was waiting to see them outside," he says.

Post-rescue, they became the toast of the season. They even appeared on reality show *Indian Idol*. "We met Shreya Ghoshal, Vishal Dadlani and Kumar Sanu. They all praised us so much. We were delighted," says Rangrez. Along with praise came cash rewards, among others, from Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav and BJP MP Manoj Tiwari. But it was the cheque that Uttarakhand chief minister Pushkar Singh Dhami handed each one of them that the group is reluctant to encash. "Instead of just Rs 50,000, he could have given us the means to make our lives better, permanently," Munna says. "They called us heroes. Is this a hero's reward?" ■